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From the editor-in-chief

There's an old journalistic axiom that bad news sells. That is reflected every day on our television screens and newspaper headlines. From the lingering impact of the global economic meltdown to acts of terrorism, new pandemics and lately, natural disasters, the bad news seems unending. Yet, in every depressing story there is always a silver lining, an act of courage, independence and enterprise that shows the resilience of the human spirit. It was precisely that which we have tried to capture in our year-long Spirit of India series where we highlight individuals and institutions that continue to inspire and uplift in the face of daunting odds. Nothing faces more daunting odds than the crucial area of infrastructure, the focus area of this issue. India is the fifth-largest producer of electricity in the world. It has the second-largest road network in the world, the second-largest rail network under a single management, and a civil aviation market that will touch 100 million passengers by next year. It also has the third-largest number of telephone subscribers the world over. Yet the Indian infrastructure story is usually one of short-ages, blockages and leakages. Whether it is energy or urban infrastructure, roads or ports, India has unfortunately rarely been known for its efficiency. There have been a few shining examples that have been written about but there are others lesser known but equally important for the role they have played in the infrastructure arena.

The Spirit of India Special on infrastructure looks at 40 such drivers of growth. There is the Konkan Railway that has built the 760-km track that offers travellers a breathtaking view of the Sahyadri Hills on the one side and the Arabian Sea on the other. There is Asia's first privately owned integrated iron and steel plant, Tata Steel's Jamshedpur works that produces 6.8 million tonnes of steel, or BHEL which is getting ready to take on China with an order book position of over Rs 1,17,000 crore. And then there is the eight-decade-old engineering and construction company, HCC, that has constructed more than 23 per cent of India's hydel and over 50 per cent of India's nuclear power generation capacities. Whether it's the ground-breaking Delhi Metro Rail Corporation that has changed the face of India's capital or IRB Infrastructure, one of the largest toll road corridor builders in the country that has built 1,150 km of road and earns a revenue of Rs 2 crore a day, these are milestones that cannot be ignored. There are challenges, of course, and we have picked an array of experts to address them and highlight what needs to be done in key sectors.

This issue was put together by Executive Editor Kaveree Bamzai with extensive reporting by, among others, Senior Editor Amarnath K. Menon from Hyderabad, a city that is transforming itself in ideal ways. Infrastructure, as everyone knows, will be the key challenge for India's growth story and John F. Kennedy's famous words come to my mind: "American roads are not good because America is rich, but America is rich because American roads are good." Hopefully, the same will happen in India too.

(Aroon Purie)



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